ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

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Cybersecurity and Online Safety: Protect Your Accounts, Data and Future

Practical account security, phishing defence and the legal risks of cybercrime

DIGITAL SKILLS

Digital Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Students are targeted because they hold bank details, social accounts and personal data with limited security habits. This pack covers strong authentication, phishing recognition, device hygiene and the Nigerian legal consequences of offences such as identity theft and unauthorised access.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Secure accounts with strong passwords and two-factor authentication.
- Recognise phishing messages and verify links before clicking.
- Apply device and data hygiene practices.
- Explain the legal consequences of common cybercrimes in Nigeria.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Account security

Most account compromise comes from reused passwords and social engineering, not sophisticated hacking.

- Use a unique passphrase for every important account.
- Enable two-factor authentication, preferably an authenticator app over SMS.
- Never share one-time passwords, even with someone claiming to be support.
- Review connected apps and revoke access you do not recognise.
- Lock your phone and laptop with a PIN or biometric, and encrypt if available.

- Log out of shared computers and never save passwords on public devices.

Phishing and social engineering

Attackers persuade; they rarely need to break in.

- Check the sender address, not just the display name.
- Hover over links to see the real destination before clicking.
- Be suspicious of urgency, threats, and requests for codes or payments.
- Verify unusual requests through a second channel you initiate.
- Treat attachments from unknown senders as dangerous.
- Report phishing to the platform and delete it; do not forward it.

> **The OTP rule**
> No bank, university or platform will ask for your OTP. Anyone who does is committing fraud, regardless of how official they sound.

Device hygiene and the law

Digital habits have legal and reputational consequences.

- Update operating systems and apps; updates patch known vulnerabilities.
- Back up important files to two locations.
- Avoid cracked software, which often carries malware.
- Do not use another person's credentials or access systems without authorisation.
- Under the Cybercrimes Act, offences include unauthorised access, identity theft, cyberstalking and phishing, with serious penalties.
- Online behaviour is permanent; screenshots and logs outlive deletion.

The threats that actually reach students

Most online harm comes through a handful of routes: phishing messages that steal passwords, fraudulent payment requests, account takeover through reused passwords, sextortion using stolen images, malware from pirated software, and identity misuse of photographs and documents.

Cybercrime is also something students can commit without realising it: using someone else's account, accessing a system without permission, sharing pirated material, or forwarding intimate images. In Nigeria these are criminal offences with real penalties, and "I did not know" is not a defence.

The common thread in victimisation is urgency. Fraud works by making you act before you think. Any message demanding immediate action - pay now, verify now, send the code now - is a reason to slow down, not to hurry.

Habits that prevent most incidents

Use a unique password for every important account and a password manager to hold them. Reused passwords are why one breach becomes ten. Turn on two-factor authentication everywhere it is offered, and prefer an authenticator app over SMS where possible.

Never share a one-time code. No bank, platform or university will ask for it. A code read aloud is a login or transfer authorised by you, whoever is asking.

Keep devices updated, install software only from official sources, and back up important files to two places. Ransomware and device theft are survivable with backups and catastrophic without them.

> **Slow is safe**
> Any message that pressures you to act within minutes is a message to verify through a channel you chose. The pressure is the attack.

If you are targeted

For account takeover: change the password from a different device, revoke active sessions, enable two-factor authentication, and check recovery email and phone settings for changes the attacker made.

For financial fraud: contact your bank immediately, report to the police cybercrime unit, and preserve every message and transaction reference. Speed matters more than dignity; delays reduce recovery.

For sextortion or image-based abuse: do not pay, do not send more, preserve evidence, report to the platform and to the authorities, and seek support. Paying increases demands and never ends them.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Responding to a phishing message

An email says your student portal will be closed unless you log in through a link within 24 hours.

1. Do not click the link.
2. Inspect the sender address and the link target without clicking.
3. Open the portal by typing the official address yourself.
4. Check whether any notice exists there.
5. Report the message to the institution's IT service.
6. If you already entered credentials, change the password and enable two-factor authentication immediately.

> **What to carry forward**
> Navigate to the service yourself. Never log in through a link in a message.

2. Recovering a compromised account

You can no longer log in and friends report strange messages from your account.

1. Use the platform's account recovery from a device you trust.
2. Change the password to a new unique one.
3. Revoke all active sessions and connected apps.
4. Enable two-factor authentication.
5. Check recovery email and phone numbers and correct them.
6. Warn contacts that messages from the account were not from you.

> **What to carry forward**
> Password, sessions, two-factor, recovery details. In that order.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain how phishing works and the habits that defeat it.

15 marks

1. Impersonation plus urgency plus a link or attachment.
2. Defences: never log in via links, verify through independent channels, inspect sender and URL.
3. Two-factor authentication limits the damage of a stolen password.

Q2. Identify three online behaviours that constitute criminal offences.

10 marks

1. Unauthorised access to a system or account.
2. Fraudulent requests for money or credentials.
3. Sharing intimate images without consent.
4. Distribution of pirated material where prohibited.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Phishing. A fraudulent message designed to obtain credentials or money.

Two-factor authentication. A second verification step beyond a password.

One-time code. A single-use code authorising a login or transaction.

Malware. Software designed to harm or gain unauthorised access.

Ransomware. Malware that encrypts files and demands payment.

Sextortion. Threatening to publish intimate images unless demands are met.

Account takeover. Unauthorised control of another person's account.

Password manager. Software that stores and generates unique passwords.

Backup. A copy of data kept separately so it can be restored.

Digital footprint. The record of your activity left online.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Accounts

Access.

- Set unique passwords for five accounts.
- Enable two-factor authentication.
- Check recovery details.

Week 2 - Recognition

Fraud.

- Collect three suspicious messages.
- Identify the pressure tactic in each.
- Practise independent verification.

Week 3 - Devices

Hygiene.

- Update all software.
- Remove pirated applications.
- Set up two backups.

Week 4 - Response

Incident plan.

- Write your response checklist.
- Save the bank fraud number.
- Know how to report to the cybercrime unit.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Your institution's IT security guidance.
- Your bank's fraud prevention advice.
- The Cybercrimes Act and a plain-language summary of its offences.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why is two-factor authentication important?

Answer: It adds a second verification step, so a stolen password alone is not enough to access the account.

2. Give three signs of a phishing message.

Answer: Urgency, a mismatched sender or link, and a request for credentials, codes or payment.

3. What should you do if you receive an OTP request from someone claiming to be a bank officer?

Answer: Refuse, hang up, and contact the bank through its official number.

4. Name two offences under Nigerian cybercrime law.

Answer: Unauthorised access to a computer system and identity theft; phishing and cyberstalking are also offences.

5. Why avoid cracked software?

Answer: It frequently contains malware and has no security updates, exposing your accounts and files.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Set unique passwords for your email, bank and school portal.
- [ ] Enable two-factor authentication on email and social accounts.
- [ ] Review connected apps and revoke unfamiliar access.
- [ ] Check three links by hovering before clicking.
- [ ] Update your phone, laptop and key apps.
- [ ] Back up essential files to a second location.
- [ ] Read a summary of the Cybercrimes Act and note three offences.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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